

Flour Frontier Executive Summary

Jake Gilstein · General Mills · NAF Sales · FSI West Zone · Flour Frontier

Project Overview

My summer internship project at General Mills set out to answer one question: where should NAF FSI focus flour over the next ten years? I built the analysis with Tableau, Nielsen DMA data, Circana data, Census projections, distributor invoice records, and conversations with both the FSI management team and the Account Executives who own the territories.

Strategic Readout

The work points to five metro priorities: Houston, Dallas-Fort Worth, Atlanta, Tampa and Phoenix. The ranking is not only about which markets are growing fastest. It compares market scale, growth, current General Mills flour position, distributor movement, cost-to-serve, and field validation. Houston and Dallas matter because the opportunity is large and immediate. Atlanta, Tampa, and Phoenix matter because they combine regional growth with clear reasons for sharper focus.

Priority Metro Logic

Rank	Metro	Why it matters	Strategic posture
1	Houston	Largest accessible upside and meaningful GMI gap	Prioritize aggressively
2	Dallas-Fort Worth	Healthy market with distributor momentum to rebuild	Recover and refocus
3	Atlanta	Southeast growth anchor with regional reach	Expand coverage
4	Tampa St. Pete	Fastest growing top five metro, building steadily	Build steadily
5	Phoenix	High growth market opportunity in the mountain west	Strengthen position

Overarching Insights and Big Ideas

What the analysis is showing	What NAF FSI should test next
The strongest opportunities sit where there is overlap. Market demand, GMI underweight position, and realistic network all need to be weighted.	Test changing direct truck minimums from 3 trucks to 2 trucks a month where it improves access without breaking economics.
Field insight matters because distributor relationships, operator mix, and account changes explain what the data models cannot see alone.	Target ethnic in store bakeries more deliberately, especially Hispanic operators in metros like Houston, Los Angeles, Tampa, and South Florida.
The current network should remain the base case. The better question is how to use mills, warehouses, lanes, and minimums more effectively.	Move toward cleaner label flour solutions, including ascorbic acid and enzyme based options, with All Trumps Green as a practical proof point.
FSI needs stronger visibility. Flour is a large, strategic business, but its marketing presence does not match the size of the opportunity.	Build a stronger FSI marketing presence through clearer sell stories, better operator-facing materials, social media and sharper metro level account targeting.

Leadership Takeaway

Flour Frontier is a practical allocation and execution plan for getting more out of the current system. The immediate value is knowing where to lean in, where to protect position, and where the field believes the data needs pressure testing. The best next step is to use the top five metros as a focused FY27 test bed for distributor engagement, account targeting, cleaner label selling, and cost to serve improvement.

Jake Gilstein · General Mills · NAF Sales · FSI West Zone · Flour Frontier